

DECISION AID

Build-vs-Buy AI Decision Matrix

Use this when the real question is not which AI vendor looks strongest, but where the workflow logic, data risk, switching cost, and operating ownership should actually sit.

Best for

Leaders comparing vendor software, lean API workflows, retrieval systems, or higher-control internal builds.

Use when

The buying conversation is happening before the workflow, governance, and ownership logic are clear.

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Decision before comparison

Start by defining the workflow, exception load, data sensitivity, and operating owner. Only then compare vendors, build options, or internal-control paths.

Option A. Off-the-shelf vendor software

- Best for common, stable workflows.
- Good when speed matters more than custom control.
- Main caution: a polished demo can hide thin product substance.

Option B. OpenAI API workflow

- Best for focused workflows that need moderate customization.
- Good when routing, prompts, and review logic need tighter control.
- Main caution: monitoring and exception design remain your problem.

Option C. Retrieval or narrower tuned system

- Best for knowledge-heavy workflows where grounding matters.
- Good when citation quality and permissioning are central.
- Main caution: retrieval quality and freshness often determine trust.

Option D. Higher-control in-house system

- Best for high-consequence workflows or sensitive logic.
- Good when governance and switching control outweigh speed.
- Main caution: the internal burden rises quickly without a real owner.

Option	Speed	Control	Best fit	Main caution
Vendor software	High	Low to medium	Generic, stable workflows	Demo quality can overstate product depth
API workflow	Medium to high	Medium to high	Specific workflow builds	Needs explicit monitoring and guardrails
Retrieval or tuned system	Medium	Medium to high	Knowledge-grounded decisions	Permissioning and evaluation are easy to underestimate
Higher-control in-house	Low to medium	High	Sensitive, strategic workflows	Slower start and heavier internal burden

Score each option from 1 to 5**Workflow fit**

Does it match the real process?

Exception burden

How much messy reality still lands on humans?

Data sensitivity

How much control is needed over logs, prompts, and storage?

Integration load

How hard is it to make this operational?

Governance strength

Can the business

Cost clarity

Can production

Switching cost

How painful is a

Ownership realism

Is there a real

audit and reverse failure?	cost be modeled credibly?	bad decision later?	operator after launch?
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Final test:

If the team still cannot explain what workflow is improving, where the risk should sit, who owns the process after launch, and what the real production cost will be, the decision is still too early.